The Origins of the Modern State

Comparative Politics

September 27-October 1, 2021

News Reports

Assignment	Date
News Report 1	October 1
News Report 2	October 15
News Report 3	October 29
News Report 4	November 12
News Report 5	December 10

Goal

- Apply course material to current **"political"** events in a **"region"** of your choosing
- **Political:** Anything interesting to approach from a power imbalance/struggle perspective
- **Region:** Need not be countries `(e.g. Latin America, China, Louisiana, New Orleans, Orleans Parish)`
- Free to change original focus after consulting with me

Delivery

- Use any creative medium to deliver your report `(e.g. audio, video, illustration)`
- Be creative, only requisites are:
  - Report can be uploaded or linked to Canvas
  - If linked, has to stay live for the rest of the semester
  - Can be graded within a week
- Meet with me if you want to discuss group proposals
- Don't overdo it!

First report

- Must be a 2-3 pages document
- Propose a region of the world and topic
- Explain why it is interesting to apply course material
- Include a list of five potential news sources
- Outline the creative media you will use to deliver the report

Subsequent reports must include

1. Summary of events/opinions
2. Justify why these are important
3. Your own thoughts or opinions `(use course material!)`

- If any of this is not obvious from your delivery, attach a short document explaining your thinking
- An excellent news report uses the course material to shed new light on our understanding of recent events

Not sure what to do?

- The default would be a written analysis piece (2-3 pages) similar to a **Monkey Cage article**
- Meet with me to discuss your interest/skills

Last time

- Everything is politics
- Not always useful to approach stuff from a political angle
- Exit, Voice, Loyalty as one of many **models to understand political situations**
- Now we have a sense of what **Political Science** is about
- **Comparative Politics** is one of its subfields
- *The study of politics within countries*

What is a country?

country Add to list Share

A *country* is a nation, a body of land with one government. Also, rural areas outside cities and towns are called the *country*.

There are many countries in the world: places that have a central government and a common identity. America was once just a bunch of colonies of England. It wasn't until they fought for independence from England that America became a country. Also, "the *country*" is any place that's away from cities and rural: the country has farms and open spaces. Country life is quieter than city life — except for the early morning roosters.

nation Add to list Share

A *nation* is a country and its people. It's also the word used for the Native American tribal federations in the US — the Cherokee *Nation*, for instance — which have their own governments and territories.

Nation comes from the Latin root *nat-*, which means "born" — the neonatal unit in a hospital is where the newborn babies are cared for. You can also use *nation* more loosely for ethnic or religious groups: you might speak of "the Jewish *nation*," meaning not just the country, or nation, of Israel, but Jews all over the world. The Nation of Islam is an African-American Muslim group.

- We tend to use words like country, nation, and state interchangeably
- We need more precision than everyday language
- The focal term in CP is *the* **state**

Classic definitions of the state

- **Weber** (1918): A human community that (successfully) claims the `monopoly of the legitimate use of physical force` within a given `territory`
- Important pieces:
  - **Territory:** Distinguishes states from nations
  - **Legitimacy:** Depends on who you ask
  - **Monopoly of force:** A very high bar, many countries deal with organized crime and paramilitary organizations

Classic definitions of the state

- **Tilly** (1985): Relatively `centralized, differentiated` organizations, the officials of which, more or less, successfully claim `control over the chief concentrated means of violence` within a population inhabiting a `large contiguous territory`
    - **Centralized, differentiated:** Some form of government
    - **Control over chief means of violence:** Recognizes monopoly is a high bar
    - **Large contiguous territory:** Small countries? Indonesia? France?

Classic definitions of the state

- **North** (1981): An organization with `comparative advantage in violence`, extending over a `geographic area` whose boundaries are determined by its `power to tax citizens`
  - **Comparative advantage:** Recognizes that monopoly is hard
  - **Geographic area:** Territory
  - **Taxation:** Control (violence) + legitimacy

Working definitions

- **State:** Entity that uses threat of force to rule in a given territory `(USA, Louisiana, Afghanistan?)`
- **Nation:** Group of people sharing common identity `(language, religion, ethnicity)`
- **Nation-state** State in which a single nation predominates and has a meaningful connection to the state `(single nation?)`
- Many **multi-ethnic** states can be considered robust nation-states `(e.g. Belgium)`
- **Amendment to CGG:** A state in which `one or more nations` have a meaningful connection to the state

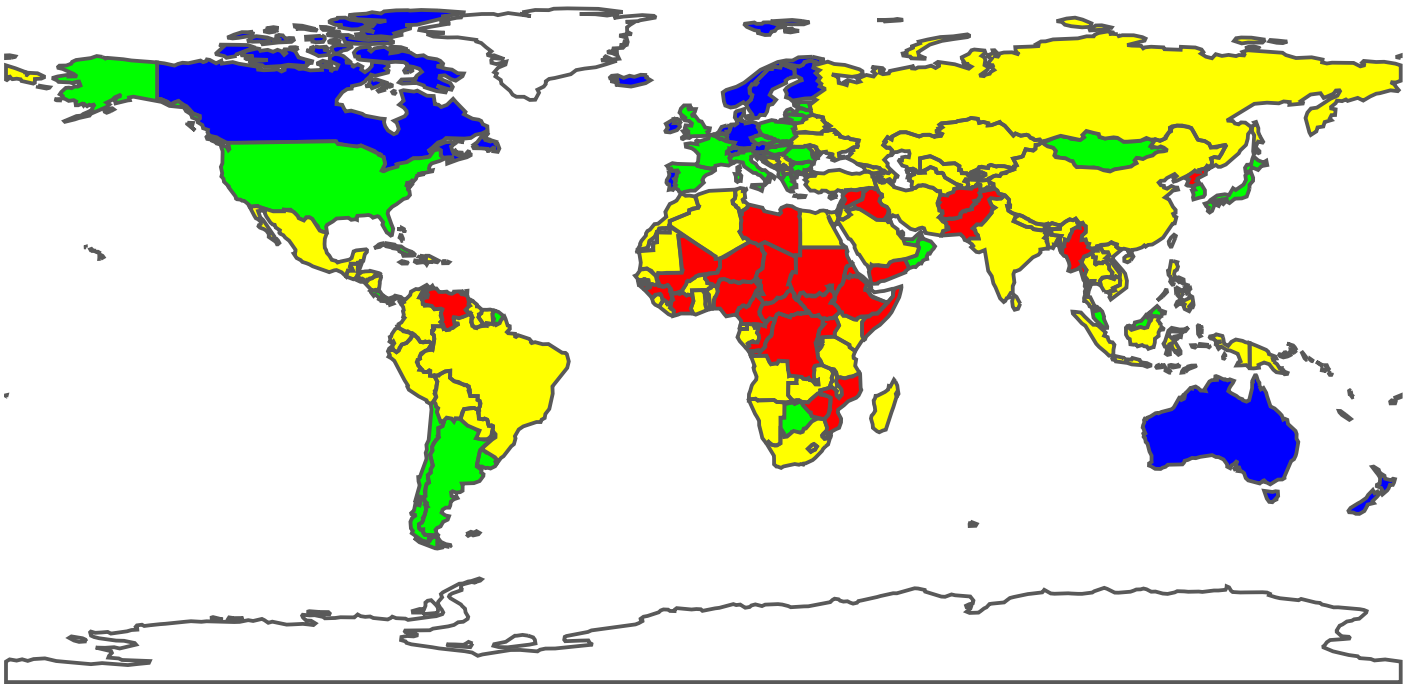
Aside: Polity

- **Polity** is the most generous, uncontroversial concept for a country-like entity
- **Definition:** An identifiable political entity
  - A group of people with collective identity, organized by institutions, with capacity to mobilize resources
  - `Examples:` Countries, (regional) states, empires, cities, international organizations

Failed states

- `State-like` entities that `cannot coerce` and are `unable to successfully control` the inhabitants of a given territory
- Textbook examples: Somalia, Syria
- Beyond these cases, we can think of **state fragility** or **stateness** as a continuum

State Fragility Index (2021)



Source: fragilestatesindex.org

State Fragility Indicators

- Aggregate Cohesion, Economic, Political, and Social indicators
- Measured through:
  1. Content Analysis
  2. Quantitative Data
  3. Qualitative Review
- **Critiques:**
  - Measures more than just **stateness** (maximalist definition)
  - Ultimately relies on `"expert"` judgment
  - Labels imposed over continuous measure are misleading `(Kenya: 89.2, North Korea: 90, Venezuela: 92.6)`

Read more about the methodology here

What Explains Variation in State Fragility?

Why are some states weaker or stronger?

Where did states came from to begin with?

Explaining the origins of the state

1. Contractarian view

2. Predatory view

Contractarian view

- **State of nature:**
  - A world with no state, government, or similar authority to regulate life
  - **Hobbes:** Everyone by themselves in constant war. Life is "solitary, poor, nasty, brutish, and short."
- **Dilemma:**
  - Everyone would be better off if they agree not to take advantage of each other
  - But if violence or theft exists, you would rather be the attacker than the victim
  - This type of dilemma is common and we can use game theory to illustrate it

The prisoner's dilemma (state of nature)

- Simultaneous game with perfect information
- 2 players with symmetric options
- Actions: `Refrain, Steal`

Prisoner's dilemma setup

	B	
	Refrain	**Steal**
A		
Refrain	$3, 3$	$1, 4$
Steal	$4, 1$	$2, 2$

- Cells denote `cardinal payoffs` (A, B)
- **Nash Equilibrium:** No incentive for unilateral defection

Prisoner's dilemma setup

		B	
		Refrain	**Steal**
A			
	Refrain	$3, 3$	$1, 4$
	Steal	$4, 1$	$2, 2$

- Cells denote `cardinal payoffs` (A, B)
- **Nash Equilibrium:** No incentive for unilateral defection
- **NE:** (Steal; Steal)
- Without state, individuals steal from each other
- Even though both would be better off if they refrained (cooperate)
- A very common problem in daily life

Solution: A social contract

- An implicit agreement among individuals in the state of nature to empower the state. It outlines rights and responsibilities of the state and the citizen with regards to each other `(e.g. state gives protection, citizen pays taxes)`

- Social contract theorists differ in the extent of power citizens delegate to state:

  - **Hobbes:** Create a sovereign with sufficient force to deter stealing
  - **Locke:** Emphasis on the contract aspect `(e.g. a constitution)`
  - **Rousseau:** Avoid tyranny of minority

- How does this translate to the prisoner's dilemma?

The state in the prisoner's dilemma (civil society game)

		B	
		Refrain	**Steal**
A			
	Refrain	$3, 3$	$1, 4 - p$
	Steal	$4 - p, 1$	$2 - p, 2 - p$

- p: Punishment from the state
- $p = 1$ makes players indifferent between refraining and stealing `(a strange scenario)`
- $p > 1$ changes the equilibrium to (Refrain, Refrain)

When do citizens opt into the social contract? (Assume $p > 1$)

State of nature

	B	
	Refrain	**Steal**
A		
Refrain	$3, 3$	$1, 4$
Steal	$4, 1$	$2, 2$

Civil society

	B	
	Refrain	**Steal**
A		
Refrain	$3 - t, 3 - t$	$1 - t, 4 - p - t$
Steal	$4 - p - t, 1 - t$	$2 - p - t, 2 - p - t$

- t: Cost of taxes `(or anything the state forces you to do)`
- Which game would citizen prefer to play?
- If $t = 1$ citizen is indifferent
- If $t > 1$ citizen prefers to stay in state of nature
- Explains origins of state
- Also explains variation in the balance of **rights** we give away in exchange for **protection** both **within** and **across** countries

The problem with the contractarian view

- **Contractarian view:** State (social contract) as a solution to conflicts of interest *between citizens*
- **Critique:** Why would anyone care about playing the role of `protector`
- **Predatory view:** Conflict of interests *between citizens and the state*

The predatory view

- **Context:** High Middle Ages in Europe. Balance of power shifting from kings to local lords
- Rulers face their own security dilemma
- Potential rivals can challenge them to take their place

- Use power to extract resource from others to become stronger and dissuade challengers

- **Tilly (1985):** The state as organized crime deploying an extortion racket

  - **State:** Sells protection
  - **Citizen:** Buys protection with taxes, loyalty, etc
  - State threatens citizens to prevent them from buying protection elsewhere

- Rulers of the state must strike balance between protection, extraction, and coercion to navigate internal and external pressures

Strategies to stay in power

1. War making `(neutralize external rivals)`
2. State making `(neutralize internal rivals)`
3. Protection `(neutralize enemies of clients)`
4. Extraction `(acquire resources to execute other strategies)`

- Rulers did not intend to create state-nations
- They are a byproduct of their efforts to stay in power
- **Over time:** Bigger states, fewer in number
- **In short:** *"War made the state, and the state made war'*

Shortcomings of the predatory view

- Does not translate beyond Europe
- Cannot explain changes in state capacity or fragility over time
- **Alternative view:** Medieval church as a rival for sovereignty (Grzymala-Busse 2020)
    - Religious conflict explains why state-like entities existed before Middle Ages `(e.g. Roman Empire)`
    - Explains why different states adopted different approaches to state-building `(religious vs. secular)`
    - Pressures for state-building after nation-states were established
    - Played a role in state-building efforts in the colonies
    - Importance of religious norms, groups, and interests to date

Reminder:

News report 1 due Friday!

Next Week:

Democracy and Dictatorship